

SUBIR HALDER

SHOW OF ANGER
Protesting SLST candidates on a hungerstrike in central Kolkata in 2019

"There was no way to find out if genuine candidates got interview calls. Even non-B.Ed. candidates made it to the merit list when a B.Ed. degree was a mandatory eligibility clause," says Islam. According to Sudip Mondal of the Mancha, around 100 candidates with lower ranks got jobs, even as those with higher ranks languished.

As the court rapped the SSC for dereliction of duty, Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee visited the dharna site in March 2019. She formed a 10-member inquiry committee, including five candidates and five education department officers. Later, some of those candidates were allegedly bought over by job offers and the movement lost steam temporarily.

On November 1, 2019, the government formed a five-member panel to look into the matter, comprising Shanti Prasad Sinha, convenor and advisor to SSC; Alok Kumar Sarkar, deputy director of education; Sukanta Acharjee, secretary to then education minister and senior TMC leader Partha Chatterjee; P.K. Bandyopadhyay (OSD to the minister); and T. Panja, senior law officer. The panel's proposals only seemed to rekindle the protesters' indignation. "The committee was arbitrary, with no one representing aggrieved candidates," says lawyer Firdous Samim, who is representing a candidate. In a new order on May 12, the court has now asked the SSC to publish a fresh list showing a complete break-up of marks along with the evaluation categories.

Before ordering the CBI to probe the alleged irregularities in the recruitment of teachers, Justice Gangopadhyay had also ordered a preliminary CBI probe into allegations over irregular recruitment of non-teaching staff in November 2021. Gangopadhyay gave another go-ahead in February 2022, but the order was stayed by a division bench of Justices Harish Tandon and Rabindranath Samanta. A judicial inquiry was initiated under retired justice Ranjit Bag to submit an independent report on the alleged scam. Justice Bag's report has pointed out that about 990 illegal appointments had taken place in Group C (clerical post) and Group D appointments in government schools.



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SUKHENDU SEKHAR RAY
TMC Rajya Sabha MP

On April 12, Justice Gangopadhyay observed that "no education department officer could act without the direction of the minister" and authorised the CBI, if necessary, to take Partha Chatterjee into custody for questioning in the teachers' recruitment case. A division bench gave him a reprieve of four weeks, which will end this month. Chatterjee has denied any involvement in the matter. The CBI grilled Sinha, who reportedly said he merely uploaded names given by influential people.

According to students and other teachers, around 400 candidates from Kazi Para, Vatra, Kirnahar and Jamna of Labhpur block in Birbhum district made it to the merit list, allegedly through a prominent minister's security officer, who hails from the area. "Each candidates paid Rs 12 lakh, to be claimed after they got appointment letters and were paid salary for two months," alleges a Labhpur school teacher. "Eleven MLAs of Birbhum had quotas between 100 and 500," as even a TMC leader claims. Corruption was reported from Tehatta and Palashipara in Nadia district too. Fingers were pointed at TMC MLA Tapas Saha by many who allegedly paid him money for teachers' jobs. Saha denies the charges.

Asked about the scam, Rajya Sabha MP and TMC spokesperson Sukhendu Sekhar Ray said, "The allegations are baseless, politically motivated. Those trying to malign Trinamool should reflect on the massive Vyapam (examination and recruitment) scam in Madhya Pradesh. The CM has taken a humanitarian step to address the problem."

Mamata has indeed decided to create posts and set the wrong right but, in a matter under CBI inquiry, it will need the court's acquiescence. Only then can the long darkness shrouding those who wait in hope be dispelled. ■